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While India is the second largest producer of milk in the world, we have never been a cheese-eating nation, with the exception of paneer or cottage cheese that's almost a staple of North Indian cuisine. For decades cheese for us has meant Amul or Britannia cheese tins. And if you wanted to try anything else you needed to rely on expensive imported cheese.

However, recently the Indian market and our palates have shifted. Over the last few years there has been a mushrooming of artisanal cheese makers across the country. Now gourmet stores such as Foodhall in Mumbai, Delhi and Bengaluru keep a variety of locally made mozzarella, burrata, gruyère, feta, etc., besides the ones inspired by local ingredients.

In fact, the pandemic saw an increased demand for cheese platters. With more and more people enter-

taining at home, the cheese platter became extremely popular.

"New trends such as keto have also been a big contributor. Cheese as a product works very well with a keto diet," says Arvind Chawla, Co-founder of Darima Farms which has an annual production of over 20 tonnes and ships pan India through their website.

"There was always a variety of cheese available but it was preposterously expensive. Now with local cheese makers, the cheese market will just continue to grow as and when people familiarise themselves with these different products... [and] they will want more of it," says chef Manu Chandra, Co-founder of Bengaluru-based Begum Victoria cheeses that came about in 2018. The cheese making facility is located on Victoria Road in the heart of Bengal-



uru and hence the name. Begum Victoria primarily focusses on crafting unique small-batch cheeses. Their double-cream brie is a top seller, as also their truffle brie. "We use real truffle. It's a premium product but there is a demand for it and it sells out rather quickly," he says.

Adds Prateeksh Mehra of Spotted Cow Fromagerie: "People have